

go about my work without feeling too bad about the horrible inequity of a world that allowed my child to enjoy a nice lunch with her even nicer nanny while this other kid went hungry and suffered. Never mind that random small gifts are not the most effective way to support the charity of your choice.

Now that we are a family of four living on just one income, it takes more planning to find a little extra to share. Here are 10 ways to find at least one charitable donation for the year:

1. Pay on the installment plan

Lots of charities, such as Chicago Public Radio, will take a monthly contribution or one-time donation. A \$120 gift then becomes 12 barely noticeable monthly payments of \$10.

2. Add an extra “person” to your holiday gift list

If a new person joins your family, there is no question that you will somehow find the cash to give them a holiday gift. Either you add a little more to your budget, or everyone else gets a slightly smaller gift, and no one suffers in the end. You can add your favorite charity to your list in the same way. This technique is most intuitive when participating in Toys for

Tots or some other children’s gift program, but you can use it for anything.

3. Gift donations

Now, this is tricky. Since most Americans already have too much stuff in their houses, and so many Christmas presents end up in the back of the closet, giving donations can be a good gifting strategy. But you can actually be selfish even while giving if you announce to everyone on your list that you’ve donated to your own favorite charity in each of their names. Charitable donations as gifts go over best if you:

Take time to choose a cause that will resonate with the recipient. For instance, my husband would be delighted if someone donated to the Electronic Frontier Foundation in his honor, but if your uncle’s an executive at one of the companies sued by this organization, he’d likely be unenchanted by the same gift.

Find out if your recipient is going to get deluged with requests for more money after your gift, and try to prevent this from happening.

Consider whether your gift will honestly be appreciated. A fresh-out-of-college niece who really needs cookware or a child may not feel so merry if all they get is a slip of paper.